FIELD NOTES: SPRING WADER COUNT

Date: 14 April. Tide: low water 07:42, height 0.9 m. Wind SW force 3, backing S by midday. Cloud 6/8, light drizzle 09:10–09:35. Visibility good beyond the drizzle. Observers: two (initials R.T. and M.V. on the tally sheets).

Started at the sluice gate at 06:15, forty minutes ahead of the published schedule, because the mud at the north end was already showing. Walked the transect south along the sea wall, stopping at the six marker posts. Counts below are from posts 1–3; posts 4–6 continue on sheet 2.

Post 1 (sluice). Mud fully exposed, thin film of water over the eastern channel. Large mixed flock feeding on the tideline, mostly dunlin with a scatter of ringed plover. Flock lifted twice when a dog was walked along the wall without a lead; counts taken after the second settle.

SPECIES	POST 1	POST 2	POST 3
Dunlin	412	186	95
Ringed plover	38	22	9
Redshank	17	31	44
Curlew	6	11	3
Grey plover	—	4	7
Oystercatcher	23	15	28

↑ 186 = recount? flock split at post 2

Post 2 (old jetty). Redshank numbers higher than the March count. Several birds in breeding plumage. Curlew feeding in the saltmarsh creeks rather than on the open mud, which is new this season.

curlew in creeks — check against last year's sheet!

Post 3 (reed bed edge). Oystercatchers roosting on the shingle spit, not feeding. Grey plover on the far mud, counted through the scope at roughly 300 m; numbers may be low because of heat shimmer once the sun came through at 08:20.

Post 4 (the bend). Water already returning up the main channel by 09:00. Birds packing tighter towards the wall. This is where the count is least reliable: the flock moves faster than it can be counted, and the scope view is partly blocked by the new fence. Recommend moving the count point 20 m south, onto the concrete apron, from next month.

SPECIES	POST 4	POST 5	POST 6
Dunlin	~~340~~ 310 *clicker*	128	12
Ringed plover	14	6	—
Redshank	52	19	8
Curlew	2	—	1
Black-tailed godwit	27	61	—
Oystercatcher	9	4	2

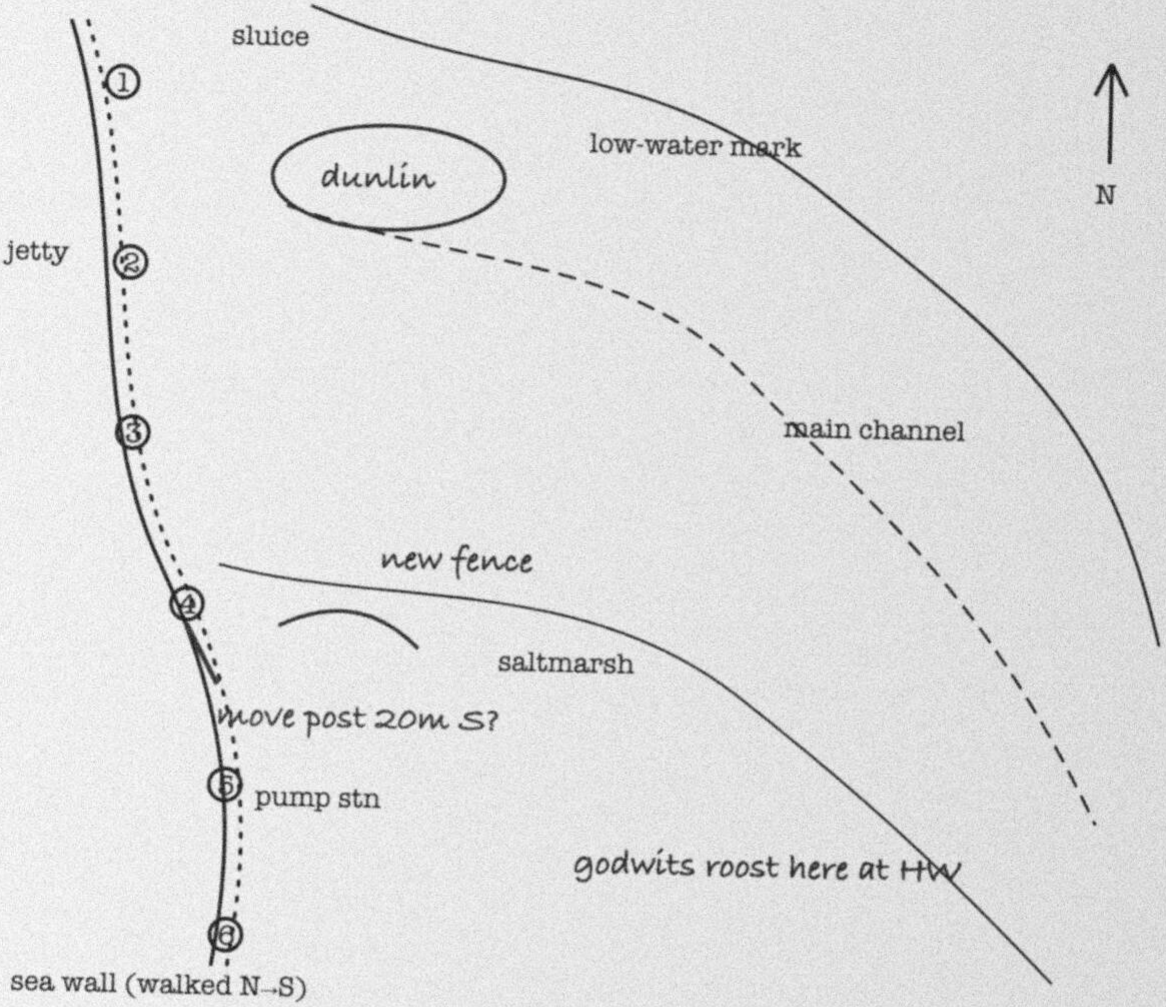
!! first godwits of spring

Post 5 (pumping station). First godwit of the spring at this post. A single colour-ringed bird among them: rings read as white over green on the left leg, red on the right. Not able to read the flag before the flock moved. Reported to the ringing scheme the same afternoon.

Post 6 (south car park). Tide over most of the mud by 09:40. Only stragglers. Ended the count at 09:52.

Ring report reply came back 16/4: bird ringed as a juvenile, 3 yrs ago, other side of the bay.

SKETCH: TRANSECT AND COUNT POSTS



Not to scale. Distances between posts approximately 350–450 m. The main channel has moved east since the last survey drawing, by an estimated 30–40 m at the bend.

TOTALS AND COMPARISON

SPECIES	APR TOTAL	MAR TOTAL	CHANGE
Dunlin	1,143	1,620	−29% migration
Ringed plover	89	71	+25%
Redshank	171	128	+34%
Curlew	23	30	−23%
Grey plover	11	15	−27%
Black-tailed godwit	88	0	new
Oystercatcher	81	94	−14%

The fall in dunlin is expected for mid-April as birds move north; the March count was close to the winter peak. The rise in redshank and ringed plover suggests the first breeding birds are back on the marsh. Godwit arrival is about a week later than last year's sheets show, though last year's count was on a bigger tide.

compare tide heights before concluding!

Disturbance events: 3 (dog off lead at post 1, twice; a low-flying light aircraft at 08:47 which put up everything between posts 2 and 4). Disturbance time lost estimated at 12 minutes in total.

Data quality: good at posts 1–3 and 5–6; fair at post 4 (see note on sheet 2). Overall confidence in totals: within about 10% for the common species.

Totals checked by M.V. — add-up agrees w/ tally sheets. ✓

NOTES FOR NEXT VISIT

1. Move the post 4 count point onto the concrete apron. Mark it with paint so the position is the same each month.

2. Start no later than one hour before low water. The north mud is exposed earlier than the tide tables suggest when the wind is in the south-west.

3. Bring the second clicker. Counting the dunlin flock at post 1 by blocks of ten was slow and the flock moved twice during the count.

4. Ask the car-park owner about a sign asking walkers to keep dogs on leads between March and June. Most people were happy to when asked.

5. Check the curlew-in-creeks observation against the saltmarsh survey sheets. If they are consistently in the creeks now, the transect may be under-counting them.

6. Next count: 12 May, low water 06:58. Same two observers if possible.

Sheets typed up from pencil notes the same evening. Pencil originals filed with the tally sheets in the survey box.

RECEIVED
18 APR
SURVEY OFFICE

#4 — sign agreed by owner, going up next wk.

— R.T.